

Access (CDMA), Evolution-Data Optimized (EVDO) or High-Speed Packet Access (HSPA) technologies. In India as well as abroad, all cellular carriers now, offer data cards to meet the ever-growing and ever-changing needs of its subscribers and the array of laptops, netbooks and now tablets.

Types of wireless cards

▶ **Plug-in models:** You have to simply plug these data cards into your laptop. You get them as USB cards and ExpressCards. These ExpressCards are like a smaller version of the older PCMCIA cards they've supplanted and have a much better battery life.

You can move these USB wireless cards and ExpressCards from one computer to another, assuming the computers can accept the card type. USB cards are usually recommended, however, because they can be shared between computers and they work on Macs, PCs and even Linux OS computers. Also, many small laptops don't have the room for an ExpressCard slot.

▶ **On-board wireless data cards:** There are certain data cards which are built into the laptop. This makes them an excellent addition to the mobile gear of people-on-the-go. The only downside is that these cards are dedicated to the laptop on which they're installed, and so they cannot be shared between devices. They also can be tougher to troubleshoot and are recommended only for true road warriors.

▶ **Multi-device cards:** The third and the last type of data card is one that can share the same connection to a cellular carrier among multiple devices at once. The pioneer of these devices is the MiFi, about the size of a credit card. You can use it in two ways:

1. You can either connect it directly to your laptop with a USB cable, like the USB data cards mentioned above or,
2. You can leave it disconnected and turned on. It will then act like a Wi-Fi hotspot for access by as many as five users (although three users is a practical maximum). Note that this use of MiFi cards can be confusing at times and is usually recommended for the computer savvy. Just make sure you remember to charge your MiFi card.

How does it work?

A USB broadband card interfaces with the connected computer using a Universal Serial Bus (USB) connector.

▶ When the device is connected, the computer interprets the device as a